

Leaders Unleashed: War Hawks and Executive Constraints

Miles D. Williams

Denison University

2026-03-25

Hawks and Constraints Both Drive Conflict Initiation

- Two literatures explain conflict initiation:
 - **Leader attributes:** hawkishness, risk tolerance, psychological traits (Carter and Smith 2020; Ellis, Horowitz, and Stam 2015)
 - **Regime type:** personalist vs. constrained regimes (Weeks 2012)
- These literatures largely talk past each other (Carter 2024a)
- This study asks: do leader attributes and institutional constraints **interact** to predict conflict?

Unconstrained Hawks Are the Greatest Threat to Peace

Preview of findings:

- Leader willingness to use force predicts conflict initiation, but only when domestic constraints are weak
- The combination of hawk bias + unconstrained authority is most dangerous

Hawkish Preferences Narrow the Bargaining Range

- In the bargaining model of war (Fearon 1995), wars are inefficient; leaders prefer negotiated settlements
- Leaders with high willingness to use force perceive war's costs as low or its gains as high (Blattman 2023)
- Result: their bargaining range narrows → more likely to reject diplomatic settlements

Unconstrained Executives Act on Hawkish Preferences

- Principal-agent theory: legislatures, parties, and citizens bear costs of war
- Strong constraints → principals can block, defund, or punish hawkish executives
- Weak constraints → leader preferences dominate state behavior

Greatest Threat at Intersection of Hawk Bias and Weak Constraints

Hypotheses:

- **H1:** Willingness to use force predicts conflict initiation only when constraints are limited
- **H2:** Lack of constraints predicts conflict only when leaders are hawkish

These hypotheses imply a Boolean “AND” (Braumoeller 2003)

Data on 130 Years of Leader-Year Observations

- **Unit of analysis:** leader-year (1875–2004)
- **Outcome:** MIC initiation (Gibler and Miller 2024), matched to individual leaders via Archigos (Goemans, Gleditsch, and Chiozza 2009)
- **Key predictors:**
 - Leader willingness to use force: latent IRT measure M2 (Carter and Smith 2020)
 - Executive constraints: Polity 2 (Marshall and Gurr 2020), V-Dem Legislative Constraints (v2x1g_legcon), V-Dem Polyarchy (Coppedge et al. 2025)
- **Controls:** CINC score, major power status, contiguous borders, cubic peace years
- **Estimation:** Logit with tensor product smoothers (Wood 2006; Hainmueller, Mummolo, and Xu 2019) + country random effects

Non-Parametric Smoothers Capture the Conditional Relationship

Model Specification:

$$\Pr(\text{MIC}_{lit} = 1) = \Lambda[\text{te}(\text{M2}_{lit}, \text{const}_{it}) + \beta X_{it} + \alpha_i + \text{p}(\text{years}_{it})]$$

- Tensor product smoothers avoid imposing a parametric functional form on the interaction (Hainmueller, Mummolo, and Xu 2019)
- Suited to testing the logical “AND” of H1 and H2 (Braumoeller 2003)
- Three models estimated—one per constraint measure—to assess robustness

Hawkish Leaders with Weak Constraints Initiate More Conflicts

Probability of MIC initiation by leaders

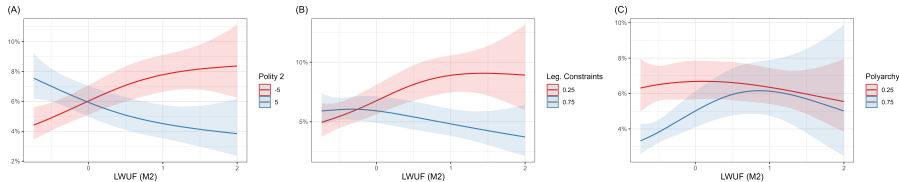


Figure 1: Conditional Predictions

- When constraints are low, the most hawkish leaders have ~8–9% probability of initiating conflict
- When constraints are high, that probability falls to ~4%
- Results hold for Polity 2 and Legislative Constraints; weaker for Polyarchy
- Suggests the mechanism is specifically about **executive constraints**

Unconstrained Hawks Initiate Wars; Constrained Hawks Do Not

- **Main finding:** Leader willingness to use force and executive constraints jointly predict conflict initiation
- Neither alone is sufficient; both are necessary
- Executive constraints specifically—not regime type broadly—are the key moderating mechanism

Limitations and Future Directions

Limitations:

- Latent M2 measure is an estimate; may misclassify some leaders (e.g., Kocharian/Armenia mentioned in paper)
- Results vary across constraint measures; no direct test of the causal pathway
- Limited to conflict *initiation*; escalation and other outcomes not addressed

Future directions:

- Extend to alliance formation, trade disputes, sanctions (Carter 2024b)
- Incorporate rivalry and geostrategic context
- Improve measurement of constraints in hybrid regimes

References I

- Blattman, Christopher. 2023. *Why We Fight: The Roots of War and the Paths to Peace*. Penguin.
- Braumoeller, Bear F. 2003. "Causal Complexity and the Study of Politics." *Political Analysis* 11 (3): 209–33.
- Carter, Jeff. 2024a. "Introduction to Special Issue: New Research on Leaders and Peace Science." *Conflict Management and Peace Science* 41 (2): 99–109.
- . 2024b. "Leader Hawkishness, Political Survival, and Interstate Crises." *The Journal of Politics* 86 (1): 337–51.
- Carter, Jeff, and Charles E Smith. 2020. "A Framework for Measuring Leaders' Willingness to Use Force." *American Political Science Review* 114 (4): 1352–58.

References II

- Coppedge, Michael, John Gerring, Carl Henrik Knutsen, Staffan I. Lindberg, Jan Teorell, David Altman, Fabio Angiolillo, et al. 2025. "V-Dem Country-Year Dataset v15." Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Project.
- Ellis, Cali Mortenson, Michael C. Horowitz, and Allan C. Stam. 2015. "Introducing the LEAD Data Set." *International Interactions* 41 (4): 718–41.
- Fearon, James D. 1995. "Rationalist Explanations for War." *International Organization* 49 (3): 379–414.
- Gibler, Douglas M, and Steven V Miller. 2024. "The Militarized Interstate Events (MIE) Dataset, 1816–2014." *Conflict Management and Peace Science* 41 (4): 463–81.

References III

- Goemans, Henk E., Kristian Skrede Gleditsch, and Giacomo Chiozza. 2009. "Introducing Archigos: A Dataset on Political Leaders." *Journal of Peace Research* 46 (2): 269–83.
- Hainmueller, Jens, Jonathan Mummolo, and Yiqing Xu. 2019. "How Much Should We Trust Estimates from Multiplicative Interaction Models? Simple Tools to Improve Empirical Practice." *Political Analysis* 27 (2): 163–92.
- Marshall, Monty G, and Ted Robert Gurr. 2020. "Polity5: Political Regime Characteristics and Transitions, 1800–2018." *Center for Systemic Peace* 2: 1–81.
- Weeks, Jessica L. 2012. "Strongmen and Straw Men: Authoritarian Regimes and the Initiation of International Conflict." *American Political Science Review* 106 (2): 326–47.

References IV

Wood, Simon N. 2006. “Low-Rank Scale-Invariant Tensor Product Smooths for Generalized Additive Mixed Models.” *Biometrics* 62 (4): 1025–36.